R FOR DATA ANALYSIS · GETTING READY · LESSON 3

03 Set your working directory

Tell R which folder holds your files, and fix the cannot change working directory error.

BY THE END OF THIS SECTION YOU WILL BE ABLE TO

- Check the current folder with getwd()
- Set a new folder with setwd()
- Fix path errors step by step

The R code in this lesson

```
# Where is R looking now?
getwd()

# Point R to your project folder (use your own path)
setwd("/Users/yourname/Desktop/R Teaching/2. Session Two")

# Check again
getwd()

# Tip: in RStudio, Session > Set Working Directory > Choose Directory also works
```

What you will hear (times count from the end of the intro)

Intro Before R can open a file, it needs to know where to look. In this lesson, you will learn to check your working directory, set a new one, and calmly fix the error that appears when the path is not quite right. Let's find our folder together.

0:00 We start with getwd. It shows the folder R is using now: the R Teaching folder on the desktop.

0:10 But our data file is inside the Session Two folder. So we use setwd, and inside the brackets, in quotes, we write the full path to that folder.

0:25 I type the path carefully: Users, my user name, Desktop, R Teaching, and Session Two.

0:45 Run it, and R says: Error, cannot change working directory. That means the path does not match a real folder exactly. Even one wrong character, or a missing space, will cause this.

1:12 Here I open the folder on the computer to check the exact folder name. The folder is called two, dot, space, Session Two.

1:25 I try again with double slashes, and a few small changes. Each time, I read the message, compare the path, and fix one thing.

1:50 And this time it works. getwd now shows the Session Two folder. In the Files pane, we can see our data file inside it.

2:30 I add clear notes in the script: understanding the working directory, and setting the working directory. Notes like these help you, and anyone who reads your script later.

2:50 Tip: if typing the path is hard, RStudio can do it for you. Use the Session menu, then Set Working Directory. Next, we will open our Excel file. Well done!